

Mini PCs

Tiny form factor computers are resurging as a category. We analyze some of the top contenders.

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MINI LAPTOPS: SMALL SIZE, SMALL PRIZE?

From Chromebooks to low-powered Windows alternatives, sub-20k small form factor laptops are a resurgent trend in the market. Are they worth buying?

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The push towards mobile, shrinking form factor devices has been evident and in full flow for a while now, but no matter what the tech gurus of the world say, laptops don't seem

to be dying fast enough. New developments take place all the time though, and inexpensive netbooks giving mobiles a run for their money. With Google pushing its Chromebooks more aggressively in India, Windows OEMs have suddenly taken to building low cost, Chromebook like laptops that seem to make a

lot of sense. These laptops cost less than ₹20,000 and rely mostly on cloud storage for functionality. And like anything in India, when the price is low, people are interested.

The question though remains as to whether these laptops are actually worth spending money on. After all,

you don't want to buy a device simply because it doesn't cost a lot of money, only to find that you made the wrong decision buying what you bought. To bring the pricing down, companies have had to make sacrifices that may not suit a lot of users. So, without further ado, here's how things stand.

HOW WE TESTED

Remember netbooks? Like a phoenix rising from the ashes, they refuse to die out. These laptops are aimed at bringing back the netbook form factor, but with a more mobile-like experience. So, we tested them the same way. It's evident that these devices are meant for the basic users, which means functionality is limited. We took one Chromebook (Xolo Chromebook) and three Win-

dows 10-based devices, namely, the Asus E402M, the Micromax Canvas Lapbook and the Acer Aspire ES 1.

We started out with two trusted benchmarks in SunSpider and Browsermark. Both these browser-based benchmarks employ various CSS, Javascript and other tests to determine what kind of browsing performance you can expect from a particular

device. Given that these laptops are cloud based and want to stay connected all the time, this is an important parameter.

Next, you'll most likely be browsing and watching movies on these devices, which means that the battery life is of utmost importance. Here, we broke up the battery life tests into two different parts. The first includes testing the battery when you're simply playing a 1080p movie

local to the device. The second test though is more important and includes the time these laptops can spend streaming videos online. Given the low storage space on these PCs, this matters.

We also tested the storage I/O speeds, data transfer speeds, and more. Further, we inspected the keyboards, touchpads, displays and the overall design of the devices to determine their usability as well.